

Restaurant Communication and Workplace Conflict

How to speak up, handle tension, and resolve conflict with coworkers, the kitchen, and management without losing your cool or your job

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- Why conflict happens in restaurants
- Communication styles and how to adapt
- Scripts for coworkers, the kitchen, and managers
- Conflict resolution planner and reflection worksheets

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Conversation scripts, de-escalation tools, and conflict planning worksheets

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CHAPTER 1

Why Restaurants Are Conflict Hot Spots

Restaurants put a lot of people in a small, hot, loud space under constant time pressure. Everyone depends on everyone else, and money depends on the whole team performing. It's no surprise tempers flare.

Common sources of conflict

Source	What it looks like
Pressure and speed	Snapping at each other during a rush
FOH vs. BOH tension	Servers blaming the kitchen for slow food; cooks blaming servers for wrong tickets
Uneven workloads	Some people doing more side work, getting more tables, or covering more shifts
Money	Tip pools, tip-outs, and section assignments that feel unfair
Scheduling	Favoritism, last-minute changes, shift swaps gone wrong
Personalities and gossip	Cliques, rumors, and personal drama spilling into work
Poor communication	Unclear expectations, assumptions, and things "lost in translation"

Conflict isn't always bad. Handled well, it can fix real problems, like an unfair side work system or a broken ticket process. Handled badly, it poisons the whole team.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding Communication Styles

Most people lean toward one of four styles. Knowing yours, and recognizing others', makes conflict easier to navigate.

Style	What it looks like	The effect
Passive	Staying quiet, avoiding conflict, going along to keep the peace	Resentment builds; problems don't get fixed
Aggressive	Yelling, blaming, interrupting, intimidating	People get defensive or shut down
Passive-aggressive	Sarcasm, silent treatment, gossip, "forgetting" on purpose	Trust breaks down; tension lingers
Assertive	Stating needs clearly and respectfully while listening to others	Problems get solved; respect grows

The goal: assertive communication

Assertive communication means being honest about what you need while respecting the other person. It sounds like:

- "I need..." instead of "You never..."
- "I noticed..." instead of "You always..."
- "Can we figure out..." instead of "This is your fault."

The "I" statement formula

When [specific situation], **I feel** [emotion], **because** [impact]. **Could we** [request]?

Example: "When my tickets get fired late, I feel stressed, because my tables wait and my tips drop. Could we go over the timing process together before tomorrow's shift?"

CHAPTER 3

Communicating Under Pressure

The middle of a rush is the worst time for a deep conversation, but the most common time for conflict.

During the rush

- **Keep it short and specific.** "I need table 12's salmon re-fired, no butter, allergy."
- **Stay neutral.** Tone matters more than words when everyone's stressed.
- **Save the bigger conversation** for later: "Can we talk about this after the rush?"
- **Don't take the heat personally.** Someone snapping in the weeds often isn't about you.

Take a pause before responding

When you feel your temper rising, try **STOP**:

- **Stop** what you're about to say.
- **Take** a breath, or two.
- **Observe** what's actually happening and how you're feeling.
- **Proceed** with a calm, intentional response.

Try this: If you need to, step away for 30 seconds: check the walk-in, refill ice, or take a quick breather. It's better than saying something you'll regret.

CHAPTER 4

FOH and BOH: Working with the Kitchen

The front and back of house often see the same problem from opposite sides. Building a good relationship with the kitchen makes every shift easier.

What the kitchen wishes servers knew

- A ticket with missing modifiers or allergies creates problems that are hard to fix mid-rush.
- "Where's my food?" every two minutes slows them down.
- Ringing in orders all at once creates bottlenecks.
- A "thank you" at the end of the night goes a long way.

What servers wish the kitchen knew

- Guests blame the server for slow or wrong food, and it hits our tips.
- We're often relaying guest requests we don't control.
- A quick heads-up about 86'd items or delays helps us manage guests.

Building a better relationship

- Learn the cooks' names and treat them with respect.
- Ask questions about dishes when it's slow, not during a rush.
- Own your mistakes: "That was my ticket error, sorry. Can you re-fire it?"
- Share positive guest feedback with the kitchen.

CHAPTER 5

Conflict with Coworkers

Before you address it, ask yourself

- Is this a one-time thing or a pattern?
- Could there be a misunderstanding?
- What outcome do I actually want?
- Is this something I can handle directly, or do I need a manager?

The 5-step conversation

1. **Pick the right time and place:** private, calm, not during service.
2. **Open with respect:** "Hey, do you have a few minutes to talk about something?"
3. **Describe, don't accuse:** use "I" statements and specific examples.
4. **Listen to their side** without interrupting. Ask questions.
5. **Agree on a solution** you can both live with, and follow up.

Scripts for common situations

Situation	What you can say
A coworker skips side work	"I've noticed the side work list hasn't been done on our shared closes. Can we split it up so it's fair?"
Someone steals your tables	"I think table 9 was mine per the seating chart. Can we check with the host so we're on the same page?"
A coworker is rude to you	"I didn't love how that came across earlier. I'd rather we talk to each other with respect, even when it's busy."
Someone gossips about you	"I heard some things were said about me. I'd rather you come to me directly if there's a problem."
A shift swap falls through	"We agreed on the swap for Saturday, and it didn't happen. Can we confirm swaps in writing going forward?"
Tip-out disagreements	"Can we look at the tip-out sheet together? I want to make sure I understand how it was calculated."

Important: If a coworker's behavior involves harassment, threats, discrimination, or violence, don't try to handle it alone. Report it to a manager or HR, and document it (see Guide 03).

CHAPTER 6

Conflict with Management

Disagreeing with a manager can feel risky. Done well, it can build respect and solve real problems.

Tips for talking to a manager

- **Ask for a private meeting** at a calm time: "Do you have 10 minutes before the shift?"
- **Come prepared** with specifics: dates, examples, and a suggested solution.
- **Focus on the business impact:** "When I'm triple-sat without a busser, service slows and guests complain."
- **Stay professional**, even if they don't.
- **Follow up in writing:** "Thanks for meeting today. Just to recap, we agreed that..."

Scripts for common manager conversations

Situation	What you can say
Unfair scheduling	"I've noticed my shifts dropped over the past three weeks. Can you help me understand why, and what I can do to get more hours?"
Being corrected in front of guests	"I want to fix mistakes, and I'm open to feedback. Could we have those conversations privately?"
Unclear expectations	"I want to make sure I'm meeting your standards. Could you walk me through what you're looking for on closes?"
Asking for help during a rush	"I'm at capacity and my tables are waiting. Can you help run food or seat the next party elsewhere?"
Receiving a write-up you disagree with	"I'd like to add my written response to this before I sign it."

When a conversation isn't enough

If a manager ignores your concerns, retaliates, or treats you unfairly, go up the chain: a general manager, owner, or HR. Document everything, and see Guides 03 and 06 for next steps.

CHAPTER 7

De-escalation: Calming a Heated Moment

When someone is already angry, whether it's a coworker, a manager, or a guest, your goal is to lower the temperature.

Do

- Keep your voice low and slow.
- Keep your body relaxed and non-threatening. Don't cross your arms or step closer.
- Acknowledge the emotion: "I can tell you're frustrated."
- Offer a next step: "Let's figure this out after the rush."

Don't

- Match their volume or tone.
- Say "Calm down." (It almost never works.)
- Argue about who's right in the moment.
- Bring up past issues.

Important: If anyone becomes physically threatening, remove yourself from the situation and get a manager or security immediately. Your safety comes first.

CHAPTER 8

Receiving and Giving Feedback

Receiving feedback

- Listen without interrupting, even if you disagree.
- Ask clarifying questions: "Can you give me an example?"
- Thank the person, then take time to think it over.
- If feedback feels unfair, respond calmly later, with specifics.

Giving feedback (as a coworker, trainer, or lead)

- Give it privately, and promptly.
- Be specific about the behavior, not the person.
- Include what's going well, too.
- Offer help: "Want me to show you how I do the closing checklist?"

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: Conflict Resolution Planner

Use this before a hard conversation.

Who is the conflict with?

What exactly happened? (facts only)

How has it affected me or my work?

What might their side of the story be?

What outcome do I want?

My opening line:

My "I" statement (When..., I feel..., because..., Could we...):

Best time and place to talk:

If it doesn't go well, my next step:

TOOLKIT

Worksheet: After the Conversation

What went well:

What I'd do differently next time:

What we agreed on:

Follow-up date:

My communication style check

- I tend to avoid conflict (passive)
- I tend to react loudly or blame (aggressive)
- I tend to vent to others instead of addressing it (passive-aggressive)
- I'm working toward saying what I need clearly and respectfully (assertive)

One communication habit I want to change:

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